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Exam Hack of the Day

"IE" vs "EI" — The Spelling Rule

The Golden Rule:

"I before E, except after C."

Use IE

(the default)

believe
piece
achieve
chief
thief
field
grief
brief
fiery
sieve
shield
yield

Use EI

(after the letter C)

receive
ceiling
deceive
conceive
receipt
perceive

Notice: C always comes right before the "ei"

Also EI

(when it sounds like "ay")

weigh
neighbour
reign
vein
eight
freight
beige
sleigh

Memory trick:

By default, always write IE. Only switch to EI if:

1) there's a C right before it or 2) it sounds like "ay"

Common exceptions to memorise:

weird their foreign height either neither
seize protein caffeine leisure science species

(These break the rule — just learn them by heart.)

NOTE: Spelling errors lose you marks under vocabulary (V). When in doubt, default to IE — it covers the majority of cases.

MISS JAY
O & A LEVEL ENGLISH